Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

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- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at:
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

```
  .  – any character
  *  – zero or more
  +  – one or more
  ?  – zero or one / lazy match
  ^  – start of line / negation in class
  $  – end of line
( )  – capture group
[ ]  – character class
{ }  – repetition count
  |  – alternation
  \  – escape character itself
```

1.4 Launching

- **helix**
- **helix** <file>
- **helix** <file1> <file2> … <filen>
- **helix** <directory>
- **helix** –help
- **hx** in some distributions or by alias

1.5 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

`v3wd` – enter select mode, select 3 words, delete

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

`u / U`	– undo / redo change in linear history
`Alt-u / Alt-U`	– move backward / forward in tree history
`:ear / :lat`	– move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
`<nn><cmd>`	– repeat <cmd> <nn> times
`Esc`	– return to normal mode

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

`:wq`	– write current buffer and quit
`:wq <file>`	– write current buffer to <file> and quit
`:wqa`	– write all buffer(s) and quit
`:q`	– quit current buffer, exits if last

2.1.2 Files

`:o <file>`	– open <file> in new buffer
`:w <file>`	– write current buffer to <file>
`:hs <file>`	– open/create <file> in new horizontal split
`:vs <file>`	– open/create <file> in new vertical split
`␣wf`	– open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
`␣wF`	– open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
`gf`	– open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
`␣f`	– open file picker at LSP workspace root
`␣F`	– open file picker at current working directory
`␣g`	– open changed file picker

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
<enter> – open selected in current view
 Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
 Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
     :n – create new scratch buffer
    :bc – close current buffer
   :bca – close all buffers
   :bco – close all but current buffer
    :bn – next buffer
    ␣b – open buffer picker

    ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
    gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
    gn – go to next buffer
    gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

`␣ws` / `␣wv`	–	split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
`␣wns` / `␣wnv`	–	split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
`␣wq`	–	close current split
`␣wo`	–	close all but current split
`␣ww`	–	next split
`␣wh/j/k/l`	–	move to buffer left / up / down / right
`␣wH/J/K/L`	–	swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
`␣wt`	–	transpose split

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

`Z`	–	enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
`zz, zc`	–	align to center
`zt`	–	align to top
`zb`	–	align to bottom
`zm`	–	align to middle horizontally
`zj`	–	scroll down
`zk`	–	scroll up

2.1.5 Help

```
    :tutor – open tutorial
        ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
        h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
         gh, g| – beginning of line
         <nn>g| – column <nn>
             gl – end of line
             gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
             ge – bottom of file
             gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to
                  word
              g.– to last modification in current file
             gj – down textual line
             gk – up textual line
             gs – first non-white-space char
             gt – top of screen
             gc – middle of screen
             gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation

]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change

Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
     % – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i – shrink selection
     ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object
                  indicated by <ch> below:

          w / W – word / WORD
              p – paragraph
   (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
              m –  closest surround pair
              f – function
              t – type or class
              a – argument/parameter
              c – comment
              T – test
              g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
    w / W – to start of next word / WORD
    e / E – to end of current word / WORD
    b / B – to start of current word / WORD
        x – current line, extend by line
        X – extend to line
   Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
       ]p – to next paragraph
       [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
      Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
        v – toggle select mode
      Esc – return to normal
        ) – cycle primary selection forward
        ( – cycle primary selection backward
    Alt-, – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

`s<regex>`	– matches become selections
`S`	– split on match
`Alt-s`	– split on newlines
`C / Alt-C`	– add selection below / above

2.5.2 Operations

`&`	– align on primary cursor
`Alt-<minus>`	– merge selections
`Alt-<under>`	– merge consecutive selections
`,`	– remove all except primary selection
`Alt-,`	– remove primary selection
`( / )`	– rotate primary backwards / forwards
`Alt-( / Alt-)`	– rotate content backward / forward
`K`	– keep selections matching the regex
`Alt-K`	– remove selections matching the regex

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

`i`	–	before selection
`a`	–	after selection
`I`	–	at start of line
`A`	–	at end of line
`o`	–	add line and insert below cursor
`O`	–	add line and insert above cursor
`Esc`	–	end insert (return to normal)
`.`	–	repeat last insert

2.6.2 Add

`]␣`	–	newline below
`[␣`	–	newline above
`ms<ch>`	–	add delim <ch> around selection

2.6.3 Delete

`d`	–	selection -> yank buf, delete selection
`Alt-d`	–	delete, no save
`md<ch>`	–	delete delim <ch> around selection

2.6.4 Change

```
            c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
       Alt-c – change, no save
           = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
> – Indent line(s) containing selection
< – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
        ~ – change case
        ` – set lowercase
    Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
        ␣C – Toggle block comment
    ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
           J – join lines in a selection
       Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select
               the inserted space
     <under> – trim whitespace from selection
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <width>, default 80
       :sort – sort ranges in selection
     :format – format file using external
               formatter / language server
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
       y – selection -> yank buf
       p – paste yank buf after the cursor
       P – paste yank buf before the cursor
      ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
      ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
      ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
   r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
       R – replace selection with yank buf
       " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

`/<regex>`	–	search forward for regex
`?<regex>`	–	search backward for regex
`n, N`	–	next, previous match
`*`	–	search for current selection, respect word boundaries
`Alt-*`	–	search for current selection

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

`"<ch>`	–	change to reg <ch>
`"<ch>y`	–	yank into reg <ch>
`"<ch>p`	–	paste from reg <ch>
`"<ch>R`	–	replace with reg <ch>

2.10 Macros

`"<ch>Q`	–	toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
`"<ch>q`	–	play macro in reg <ch>, default @

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
    ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
          mm – go to matching delim
     mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
     ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
       | – replace selection(s) with output
    Alt-| – ignore output
       ! –  insert output before each selection(s)
    Alt-! –  append output after each selection(s)
       $ –  keep selection(s) where command returned
            0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

`␣G` – debug - experimental
`␣k` – show documentation for item under cursor
`␣s` – open document symbol picker
`␣S` – open workspace symbol picker
`␣d` – open document diagnostics picker
`␣D` – open workspace diagnostics picker
`␣r` – rename symbol
`␣a` – apply code action
`␣h` – select symbol references for symbol under cursor

2.15 Editor Configuration

`:config-open` – open the config file
`:config-open-workspace` – open the workspace config file
`:config-reload` – reload the config file

2.16 Miscellaneous

`␣'` – open last picker
`␣/` – open global search in workspace folder picker

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

`Ctrl-s`	– commit undo checkpoint
`Ctrl-x`	– autocomplete
`Ctrl-r`	– insert a register content
`Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>`	– delete previous word
`Alt-d, Alt-<del>`	– delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	– delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	– delete to end of line
`Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>`	– delete previous char
`Ctrl-d, <del>`	– delete next char
`Ctrl-j, <enter>`	– insert new line
`<Up>, <Down>, <Left>, <Right>, <PageUp>, <PageDown>, <Home>, <End>`	– usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

`Esc, Ctrl-c`	– close prompt
`<enter>`	– open selected
`<tab>`	– select next completion item
`<backtab>`	– select previous completion item
`Alt-b`	– backward a word
`Ctrl-b`	– backward a char
`Alt-f`	– forward a word
`Ctrl-f`	– forward a char
`Ctrl-e`	– to prompt end
`Ctrl-a`	– to prompt start
`Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>`	– delete previous word
`Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>`	– delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	– delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	– delete to end of line
`<bksp>, Ctrl-h`	– delete previous char
`<del>, Ctrl-d`	– delete next char
`Ctrl-s`	– insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
`Ctrl-p`	– select previous history
`Ctrl-n`	– select next history
`Ctrl-r`	– insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
    <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                  <Home> – to first entry
                   <End> – to last entry
        Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
      Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
                 <enter> – open selected
            Alt-<enter> – open selected in the
                          background without
                          closing the picker
                 Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                 Ctrl-v – open vertically
                 Ctrl-t – toggle preview
            Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
    Ctrl-u – scroll up
    Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
      Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
         <enter> – close menu and accept completion
          Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
     Alt-p – previous signature
     Alt-n – next signature
```